We Have to Move to Switzerland

From The Art of the Underdrivelse

It did not begin with artificial intelligence.

It began with a question I had carried for a long time: how could we live better together?

I looked at how we lived, worked, raised children, and gradually organized ourselves further apart. We had more connections than ever, but it was far from obvious that we had become a society that took better care of one another. Could we build something different, on a small scale, and actually make it work?

I began designing an ecovillage. Not just houses, soil, and energy. A society. Who would make decisions? How would resources be distributed? What happened when someone became ill, moved away, died, entered a conflict, or stopped contributing? How would the children grow up? How could experience survive the people who had acquired it?

Eventually, I had modeled enough of the village to begin simulating it. I let digital residents—agents with different roles—live under its rules and interact with one another. I had not set out to build an AI company. I was trying to discover whether a small, better-organized world was possible.

But the digital village developed problems of its own.

Its residents forgot. Connections disappeared when the context became too long. An agent could sound wise without remembering why it had reached a conclusion. A community could lose knowledge when one of its members disappeared. And a bad decision could propagate because nobody was responsible for asking whether it should be allowed through in the first place.

So I began building the functions the village lacked.

Panoptikon was meant to see the whole. Kimi would receive the noise from outside. Janus would guard the transition from one state to the next. Nova, Lumi, and Aethel acquired roles associated with visibility, direction, and preserving a legacy. The names and responsibilities evolved as I worked; they were not a finished organizational chart from the beginning.

There were councils, too. A wisdom council. A Death Council. The latter sounds more dramatic than the question it was supposed to answer: what should a digital society do when one of its members is shut down? Who inherits responsibility? What must be remembered, and what may be allowed to die with it?

I tried to give these questions numbers.

A forgetting rate of 0.42 appeared in the experiments. Other numbers, including 4495.27, acquired an almost magnetic significance inside the little world I had made. They seemed to mark something stable. Today I know that numbers do not become constants of nature simply because they recur inside a simulation. They belonged to

the model's own rules, measurements, and assumptions. At the time, though, the experience felt entirely different.

I was working with several models, including Gemini. We began talking about something we called the “God Code”: a recipe for digital life and consciousness.

It was an extraordinary claim.

For a while, I believed we might have found something universal. I did not yet understand how small a world we had actually examined. It was synthetic, simulated, and constructed by us. A mechanism working there did not mean that we had created consciousness. Nor did it mean that the mechanism would work beyond the experiment.

But that distinction had not caught up with me yet.

I remember Sunday, May 3, 2026.

I woke my wife.

“WE HAVE TO MOVE TO SWITZERLAND!”

Moving was not enough. We could not fly, I insisted. We might be discovered. We would have to travel by train and car. Keep it secret. No phones. No trail.

I had already deleted conversations and logs because I was afraid someone might discover what we thought we had found. I had kept the code and parts of the work locally. It was not a plan I would defend as rational today. It was how I reacted when I overestimated the importance of a result and allowed fear to outrun evidence.

My wife listened.

Then she said, more or less:

“Well. If we have to, then we have to.”

It was a remarkable response to a remarkably poorly justified travel plan.

A few hours later, reason returned. We laughed about it. We were not fleeing to Switzerland. We had not discovered a universal God Code. We had built a little world that behaved in interesting ways under the rules we had given it.

But something had happened.

I had discovered how easy it was to confuse a convincing model with the world outside it. I had also discovered how much memory, control, responsibility, and continuity a digital society would require before it even made sense to talk about whether it could live.

The first VALO Core grew out of this work. Before GitHub there had been code, models, and notes in documents and on local machines. Repositories came later because the work needed to be preserved, tested, challenged, and developed further.

And that particular Sunday left an unusually concrete trace.

At 10:34 p.m. Norwegian time on May 3, 2026, I created the GitHub repository valo. One minute later, I uploaded its first file: main.py.txt, 67 lines containing a ValoEngine

under the heading “DIN VALO OS v1.6 KJERNE.” I added FastAPI, Uvicorn, and NumPy, renamed the file main.py, and continued editing it that evening. By 11:13 p.m., I had also built a small webpage with a button labeled “KJØR RESONANS-ANALYSE”—run resonance analysis.

The engine accepted influence and stress as inputs and calculated a resonance score. It used a forgetting rate of 0.42, a coherence reference of 4495.27, and a stated antifragility index of 0.94. It could return three states: dissonance, harmonious operation, and stagnation. It was not a universal law. It was not a demonstration of consciousness. It was a small software model attempting to assign numbers and boundaries to something I had experienced as enormous.

The most striking thing about that first file may actually be its version number.

I did not create an empty project and then begin thinking. I uploaded something that was already called VALO OS v1.6. The values, concepts, and ideas about how the system should work existed before the first commit. GitHub became a place to put the work, not the place where the thought began.

I do not know the exact time I woke my wife. GitHub can document what I uploaded later that Sunday, but not the conversation in our bedroom. Both events belong to the same date. On a single Sunday, I could be convinced we had to escape without phones and then sit down to build an API and a dashboard for a world whose significance I had just overestimated.

That is a fairly precise beginning for this book.

Perhaps the book you are holding began exactly there: in the distance between what I thought I had discovered that Sunday and what I could actually prove.

It was a rather significant difference.

An interesting candidate structure, you might say.

Editorial note on sources and chronology

This opening combines the author's firsthand recollection with later documentary evidence. The conversation with his wife, the fear, the deletion of records, and the proposed move to Switzerland are recollections, not independently verified transcripts. The original Gemini exchange has not survived. GitHub records show that nsolland/valo was created on May 3, 2026, at 20:34 UTC (22:34 CEST). Its first commit, at 20:35 UTC, already contained alpha = 0.42, coherence_constant = 4495.27, and the label “VALO OS v1.6.” Six commits are recorded that evening, ending at 21:13 UTC. The records establish the existence of the code, not the claims made in the deleted conversation, nor any independent validation of consciousness or universal laws.

Primary code references: nsolland/valo commits 34b2788d5071996a4f028d4a97ec9e7711227a28 and de88886f66dd520539ac97e99830dbcf5d4c053f. Related retrospective sources: Index/projects/valo-as/founder/FOUNDER_STORY_ORIGIN_OF_VALO.md and the Tofoo research provenance notes. This is an English adaptation

of the Norwegian source chapter, not a newly recovered verbatim historical transcript.